Radio Usage and Etiquette

Use clear, brief calls on your assigned channel. These habits apply across radio models

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Life safety comes first. Call 911 when available for immediate danger. A radio call does not mean emergency services have been notified. Do not delay evacuation or enter a hazard to make a report.

BEFORE YOU TRANSMIT

- ☐ Battery charged; spare or charging cable ready
- ☐ Antenna secure; volume audible
- ☐ Assigned channel selected; callsign known
- ☐ Receive checked; transmit only if authorized
- ☐ Push-to-talk protected from accidental use

- **Listen first.** Wait for a clear channel.
- **Press, pause, speak.** Use a normal voice; follow your microphone guide.
- **Release and listen.** Leave time for urgent calls to break-in.
- **Stay professional.** Avoid private details and speculation.

COMMON RADIO PHRASES

Phrase	Meaning
Roger / Copy	Message received. Read back critical details to confirm understanding.
Affirmative / Negative	Yes / No.
Over	Finished speaking; a reply is expected.
Out	Exchange finished; no reply expected. Do not say “over and out.”
Stand by / Standing by	Please wait / I am waiting and ready.
Go ahead	Send your message; I am listening.
Say again	Please repeat your message or the specified part.
Correction / Disregard	Correcting my message / Ignore my previous message.
Radio check	Can you hear me? / Your audio is clear.
Emergency traffic	Urgent call requesting priority; Stop talking and listen.
Traffic	Messages / Information to send/receive
Monitoring	I have no traffic, but am listening
Break	I have urgent information to share or have to briefly stop and restart transmission

Normal Operation and Directed Nets

A radio net is an organized group of stations meeting on a shared channel for a common purpose, such as check-ins, training, or emergency coordination.

WHAT MAKES A NET DIRECTED

In a **directed net**, one station acts as **Net Control** and manages who speaks and in what order. “Traffic” means a message or report to pass. “No traffic” means you are checking in without a message. A scheduled check-in can use directed procedures even when there is no emergency.

Action	Normal operation	Directed net operation
Start a call	Listen for a clear channel; call the intended member directly.	Call Net Control and wait for recognition, or answer when called.
Pass a message	Speak briefly to the station you called.	Pass traffic through Net Control; contact another station directly only when directed.
Join the activity	Identify yourself in the exchange.	Check in as instructed; give your callsign and whether you have traffic.
Finish	Close the exchange and monitor.	Stay available; tell Net Control before checking out or changing channels.
Urgent danger	Give emergency traffic priority.	Announce emergency traffic at a break; routine stations hold while Net Control handles it.

WHY THIS MATTERS IN AN EMERGENCY

Several stations transmitting together can cover up a location, a request for help, or a warning. Directed procedures give emergency reports priority, reduce overlapping calls, and let Net Control track stations, messages, and unanswered requests. Short reports, accurate readbacks, and a clear speaking order help critical information reach the right person.

Follow the directed procedure even when the channel sounds quiet. Net Control may be waiting for a reply or coordinating a relay. Listen continuously, leave pauses for urgent calls, and keep unrelated conversation off the net. Net Control coordinates radio traffic; that role does not grant incident command authority.

⌖ **LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL**

[VERIFY] Changing modes: The designated operator announces when a directed net starts, its purpose, and its channel. Use directed procedures until Net Control explicitly closes the net or transfers control. A pause or a change of operator does not return the channel to normal operation.

SOURCES

SAMPLE TEXT — NOT APPROVED ADVICE. Fire Watch owner brief (October 23, 2026). General net principles: IARU, Emergency Telecommunications Guide (September 2016), Chapters 7–11; accessed October 23, 2026. www.iaru.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/01/emcommguide_1sept2016.pdf

Radio Calls and Emergency Traffic

Use plain language to communicate: “What is your location?” is clear "what is your 20?" is not clear

On a directed net, Net Control coordinates calls. You may only speak to Net Control and no other stations unless given specific permission by net control. Listen, wait to be recognized, and report the essential facts.

PASS ROUTINE TRAFFIC DURING A DIRECTED NET

1. **Call and identify:** “Net Control, [callsign].” Release and wait for “Go ahead.” If unanswered, pause and try once more.
2. **Report** location, observation, time, threats, action taken, and help needed. Identify unconfirmed information.
3. **Confirm.** Read back critical details; ask “Say again” if unclear. End with your callsign; resume monitoring.

⌖ **LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL**

[VERIFY] Fire Watch identification: Use your assigned three-digit callsign and any legally required station ID. Address city personnel by title. Outside a net, call the member directly: “145, 238.” Wait for “This is 238, go ahead.”

GIVE EMERGENCY TRAFFIC PRIORITY

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Urgent danger: At a break, say **“Emergency traffic, [callsign].”** Release and listen for acknowledgment, then give the exact location and danger first. Other stations hold routine calls. If unanswered, use another available way to summon help.

Confirm the interruption phrase before duty: the existing brief uses **“Emergency traffic”**; the supplied sheet uses “Break, break.”

Radio Check and Field Call Examples

Practice with your assigned callsign. Replace bracketed fields with confirmed facts and exact locations.

SAMPLE RADIO CHECK

When the channel is clear and checks are permitted:
You: “Fire Watch, this is [callsign]. Radio check. Over.”
Other station: “[Callsign], loud and clear. Over.”
You: “Copy. [Callsign], out.”

REPORT DURING A DIRECTED NET

You: “Net Control, [callsign].”
Net Control: “[Callsign], go ahead.”
You: “Visible smoke near [exact location], first seen [time]. [Observed conditions]. [Help needed]. Over.”
You: Read back instructions when received; close with “[Callsign], out.”

EMERGENCY REPORT

You: “Emergency traffic, [callsign].”
Net Control: “All stations hold. [Callsign], go ahead.”
You: “[callsign] at [Exact location]. Active fire. [People or access threatened]. [Action taken]. [Help needed]. Over.”

Blocked road: give street/intersection, obstruction, and passability. Report from safety.

MONITOR UPDATES AND CHECK OUT

⌖ **LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL**

[VERIFY] Net Control updates: High activity: :00, :15, :30, :45; quieter: :00, :30; stand-down: :00 hourly. Hold routine calls for updates; follow current net instructions.

Ask to check out or report a channel/radio change before leaving the net. After duty, report equipment problems and recharge. Neighborhood radio coordination does not replace official emergency instructions.

SOURCES

SAMPLE TEXT — NOT APPROVED ADVICE. Fire Watch brief and supplied pages. Verify local procedures. Programming: COM-009; UV-PRO: COM-008.

Scheduled Check In Net Script

Use a check-in net to practice the same speaking order and acknowledgments needed during an emergency.

⌖ LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL

[VERIFY] Local script examples: Confirm Heights 6, callsign 172, the Saturday 1800 schedule, and the ten-minute duration before use. Substitute the assigned operator, channel, date, and actual times. Times below use local 24-hour time. Include any legally required station identification.

OPEN THE NET

“This is 172. For the next ten minutes I will be operating as Net Control for La Habra Heights Firewatch on Heights 6. This is a directed check-in net. Please pass all traffic through Net Control and transmit one station at a time when invited or called. At check-in, give your callsign and state whether or not you have traffic.”

“First, a break for emergency traffic.”

Release push-to-talk and listen. If emergency traffic is heard, acknowledge it and handle it before check-ins. Say “Hearing none” only after listening.

“Hearing none, stations wishing to check in, one at a time. First station, go ahead.”

ACKNOWLEDGE AND MANAGE CHECK INS

Member: “238, no traffic.”
Net Control: “238, checked in, no traffic. Next station, go ahead.”

Member: “145, with traffic.”
Net Control: “145, checked in with traffic. Stand by.”

When ready: “145, go ahead with your traffic.”

Log callsigns and pending traffic. If stations overlap, ask them to repeat one at a time or call specific stations from the roster. Before closing, ask: “Any additional check-ins or remaining traffic?” Release and listen; resolve pending messages.

CLOSE THE NET

“Thank you to all members who checked in this evening. This concludes the Saturday night 1800 net. We will do a check-in next Saturday at the same time on this frequency. I am now returning this channel to normal use by authorized members of La Habra Heights Firewatch. Net Control clear at 1810. 172 clear and monitoring.”

If an actual emergency develops, suspend the practice check-in and announce the change to emergency net operation. Do not close at ten minutes while emergency traffic remains unresolved.

SOURCES

SAMPLE TEXT — NOT APPROVED ADVICE. Adapted from Fire Watch owner script examples (October 23, 2026). Verify local schedule, identification, and procedures before duty.

Emergency Net Control Script

Keep emergency traffic moving first. Use short transmissions, release to listen, and record messages and follow-up actions.

⌖ **LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL**

[VERIFY] Activation and closure: Use the team's designated Net Control and incident coordination process. Replace bracketed fields with confirmed information. An emergency net has no automatic ten-minute end. Include required station identification.

ACTIVATE OR CHANGE FROM A CHECK IN NET

“All stations, this is [callsign], Net Control for La Habra Heights Firewatch on Heights 6. [The check-in net is suspended.] We are operating a directed emergency net for [incident or purpose]. Hold routine traffic. Pass all traffic through Net Control unless directed otherwise. Stations with emergency traffic, call now.”

Release and listen. If no emergency station answers: “Hearing none, stations with incident traffic, identify one at a time with your callsign and the nature of your traffic.” Call stations individually if responses overlap. Request general check-ins only as the situation permits.

RECEIVE EMERGENCY TRAFFIC

Member: “Emergency traffic, [callsign].”
Net Control: “All stations hold. [Callsign], go ahead with your emergency traffic.”
Member: “[Exact location]. [Immediate danger]. [People threatened]. [Action taken]. [Help needed]. Over.”

Read back the location and critical details; ask for corrections. Confirm who is contacting 911 or the appropriate response agency and whether contact succeeded. Log the report, recipient, time, and pending action. Acknowledging a radio report does not confirm dispatch or completion.

After handling the call: “Emergency traffic from [callsign] received. All stations, the directed emergency net remains active. [Next station], go ahead.” Leave a listening break for new emergency traffic.

TRANSFER NET CONTROL WITHOUT CLOSING

Brief the relief operator on checked-in stations, pending messages, and unresolved requests. After the relief operator accepts: “All stations, [new callsign] is now Net Control. The directed emergency net remains active.” The new operator confirms control on air.

CLOSE ONLY WHEN AUTHORIZED TO STAND DOWN

Confirm unresolved traffic has been completed or handed to an identified station or agency. Then announce: “All stations, this is [callsign], Net Control. The directed emergency net for [incident] is closed at [time]. [State any continuing monitoring or reporting instructions.] Heights 6 is returned to normal use by authorized members of La Habra Heights Firewatch. Net Control clear. [Callsign] clear [and monitoring, if true].”

SOURCES

SAMPLE TEXT — NOT APPROVED ADVICE. Fire Watch owner brief (October 23, 2026); IARU, Emergency Telecommunications Guide (2016), Chapters 7–11. Source URL on page 2.

NATO and LAPD Phonetic Alphabets

Use phonetic words to spell names, streets, or letter groups clearly. Say “I spell,” then give one word per letter.

Letter	NATO	LAPD	Letter	NATO	LAPD
A	Alfa	Adam	N	November	Nora
B	Bravo	Boy	O	Oscar	Ocean
C	Charlie	Charles	P	Papa	Paul
D	Delta	David	Q	Quebec	Queen
E	Echo	Edward	R	Romeo	Robert
F	Foxtrot	Frank	S	Sierra	Sam
G	Golf	George	T	Tango	Tom
H	Hotel	Henry	U	Uniform	Union
I	India	Ida	V	Victor	Victor
J	Juliett	John	W	Whiskey	William
K	Kilo	King	X	Xray	X-ray
L	Lima	Lincoln	Y	Yankee	Young
M	Mike	Mary	Z	Zulu	Zebra

Use the alphabet specified by the team or Net Control; keep it consistent within a spelling. Read back critical spellings.

SOURCES

SAMPLE TEXT — NOT APPROVED ADVICE. NATO, Phonetic alphabet, codes and signals (2018), accessed October 23, 2026. www.nato.int/alphabet. LAPD, Candidate Advancement Program Guide, “Phonetic Codes,” p. 8; accessed October 23, 2026. personnel.lacity.gov/joinlapd/pdf/LAPD_CAP_Manual.pdf